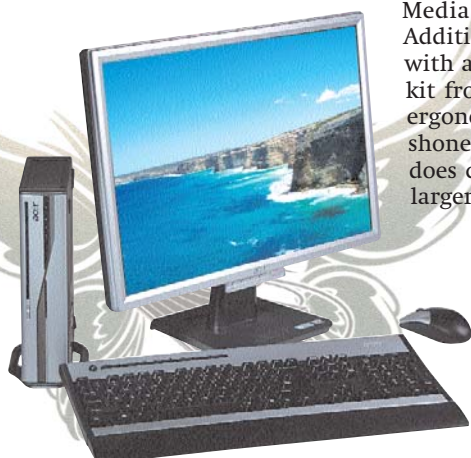


designer Desktop. Thankfully, the cable is a little longer than most.

HCL's Dominator and Beanstalk Classic Z944 come with a cartonful of goodies—loads of software, utilities, speakers, headphones, and Media Center remote controls. Additionally, the Z944 is bundled with a wireless mouse and keyboard kit from Microsoft—both have great ergonomics. The little Acer is outshone in this department—though it does come with a much better (and larger) monitor!



Acer Aspire L310
Designer Desktop!

Performance *Ready... Get Set... Go!*

Due to the small form factor typical to HTPCs, they don't run particularly cool. The Acer L310 does get hot owing to its small size—thankfully, it runs a relatively cool Core 2 Duo E6300. The real monster

in this category is the Dominator, which features a mighty Core 2 Quad (Q6600) at 2.4 GHz. Thanks to the impressive hardware, this PC hammered the competition in most CPU-intensive tests and benchmarks.

Acer misses out on a graphics card, while both HCL PCs feature cards based on NVIDIA's GeForce 7500LE chipset. Having a graphics card doesn't necessarily make these PCs good gaming machines, but the HD video playback experience is enhanced.

What really impressed about the Z944 was the colossal hard drive—a 500 GB hard disk is a really positive step by HCL, and something we hope becomes a trend. Even the Dominator only manages 250 GB.

Despite the fact that Acer's 22-inch monitor is a real show-stopper, it is, in fact, a TN panel, and has minor colour rendition issues. That said, this LCD is miles ahead of the competition—movies and games are a delight with all the pixel real estate available. Pity it runs an onboard video solution.

Conclusion *So...do I get the job?*

If you want something classy-looking and really compact with the added benefits of a large monitor and reasonably powerful components, look no further than the Acer Aspire L310. Even though it's intended as an HTPC, we'd heartily recommend it to bigwig corporates for whom a Desktop is all about making the right impression. With integrated Wi-Fi as a bonus, this little

marvel is a definite “must see before buying others.” A definite gold winner if beauty came before brains...

For sheer performance, it's hard to ignore HCL's Dominator. A quad-core processor, 2 GB of memory, and a GeForce 7-series graphics card make this one heck of a performer. It's not a hardcore gaming machine—the 7500LE will play most current-generation games at low to medium settings—but is a solid PC for multitasking and HD playback. The additional media player functionality and the feature-rich remote make it very attractive indeed—this is your *Digit Best Buy Gold*.

HCL's Beanstalk Classic Z944 is another powerful option in slim guise. It's as richly featured as the Dominator, but with a much smaller footprint, attractive looks and better speakers. The added advantage of a 500 GB hard drive is irresistible for data hogs: if you want loads of space, here's your PC...

MINNOWS Breaking the sub-20000 barrier

Although we only found two worthies in this category, it thrills to see some very decent machines at such throwaway prices! No matter what advertisements may say, a *proper* sub-20,000 PC is still partly fantasy and party wishful thinking. This is because of the extremely low margins on such a desktop, and the nightmare of providing support for comparatively cheaper (hence somewhat inferior) components. Acer and eSys have taken up the gauntlet and thrown in extremely pocket-friendly Desktops.

Features *Surprisingly enough!*

Acer's AP E361 sports a surprisingly sturdy cabinet, and is powered by a basic AMD Sempron processor running at 2 GHz. Acer's bundle is very spartan, and with a tiny 15-inch CRT, you won't be doing a lot of movie watching. We suggest upgrading to a 17-inch LCD—this will ensure a richer Internet and movie experience.

eSys' EUC3223CI provided an even sturdier cabinet, with a little more visual appeal—a partially meshed front bezel is never a bad thing.



Acer AP E361
Value has a new name!

Decision Maker			
You Want	Your Budget	We Recommend	The Price
The cheapest possible Home PC	Up to 15,000	Acer E361	13799
A basic PC with a little more punch	Up to 25000	Acer Aspire IE3214, Intex BM-45431	25999, 25900
Decent multimedia functionality	Up to 35000	Intex BM-45431, HP a6110in	25900, 31490
A decent gaming PC	Up to 45000	Sahara 20CK16	40000
Compact yet powerful Desktop	Up to 50000	Acer Aspire L310, HP s3180in	39999, 45990
Media Centre PC with remote	Up to 60000	HCL Dominator Q965 & HCL Beanstalk Classic Z944	54990, 59990
Powerful CPU-based PC for multitasking	Up to 60000	HCL Dominator Q965	59990
Large monitor for HD movies	Up to 45000	Acer Aspire L310	39999